

Egg-laying mammals

Some mammals lay eggs instead of giving birth to live young. These are the monotremes, found only in Australia and the island of New Guinea. They include the duck-billed platypus and four species of spiny-coated echidnas.



Eastern long-beaked echidna

Spiny coat

An echidna's coat is made up of protective spines interspersed with fur. If threatened, the echidna can roll into a spiky ball.



Toothless feeding

All monotremes lack teeth, and instead have sensitive beaks for catching invertebrate prey. Echidnas dig through soil with sharp claws to expose prey and use their long, sticky tongue to trap them. The platypus uses its sensitive bill to find shellfish buried in the mud, then crushes them with horny plates inside its bill.

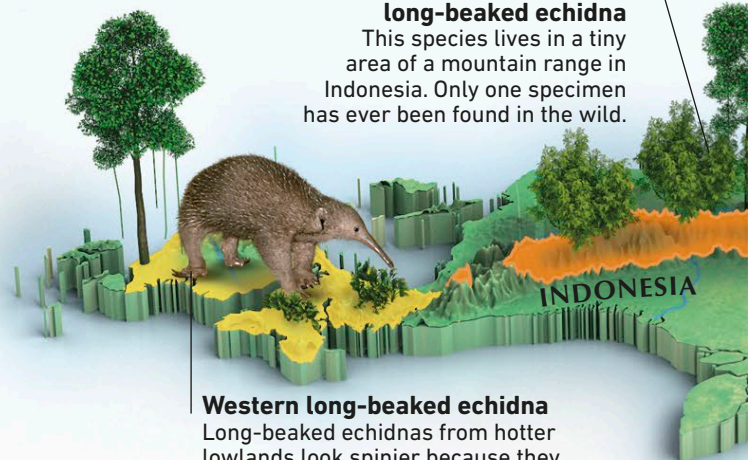
Highly adaptable

Monotremes inhabit a wide variety of habitats, from Australia's arid deserts to the snow-covered mountains of Papua New Guinea. Short-beaked echidnas are the most adaptable and have the largest range, while the other monotremes are limited to smaller areas.



Sir David's long-beaked echidna

This species lives in a tiny area of a mountain range in Indonesia. Only one specimen has ever been found in the wild.



Western long-beaked echidna

Long-beaked echidnas from hotter lowlands look spinnier because they have less insulating fur than those that live in cooler highlands.